"Today, at Vizhinjam, history, destiny and possibility came together as a 30-year-old dream of Kerala became India's gateway to the world. We are proud to have built India's first deep-sea automated port—a future global transshipment hub."

Gautam Adani, Chairman, Adani Group



ULCV MSC Turkiye came calling at Vizhinjam deep water seaport in Kerala on April 9.

What truly sets Vizhinjam apart is its digital muscle. A fleet of artificial intelligence (AI)-powered systems—eight semi-automated ship-to-shore cranes, 24 automated yard cranes, and a vessel management system developed in collaboration with the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT)-Madras—helps orchestrate the dance of ships, containers, and logistics with astonishing precision. Its integrated connectivity plan, including a dedicated 10.76 kilometre rail corridor (9 km underground), links Vizhinjam seamlessly to NH-66 and India's freight arteries, ensuring speed inland matches pace offshore.

Global confidence comes calling

The port's trial phase has already seen 7,39,000 TEUs (Twenty-foot equivalent units) handled and over 350 vessels docked. But the defining moment came when Swiss shipping giant MSC made Vizhinjam a regular stop on its Jade and Dragon routes.

Six mega vessels from MSC—including MSC Türkiye, MSC Claude Girardet, and the iconic MSC Irina—have since docked here, turning Vizhinjam into a preferred South Asian anchor. Their Liberian flags flapping in the salty breeze, these behemoths signalled a clear shift in maritime gravity.

A geopolitical lever

Vizhinjam's potential stretches far beyond cargo. It's a strategic asset in India's global playbook. Its emergence complements national initiatives like Prime Minister Gati Shakti and the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC), a counterweight to China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). With every TEU it handles, Vizhinjam enhances India's connectivity, sovereignty, and standing in the global supply chain chessboard.

Legacy meets vision

Ironically, Vizhinjam isn't new to maritime fame. As far back as the 2nd century Before Common Era (BCE), under the Ay dynasty, it was a spice-exporting hub on ancient ocean routes. In 2025, it's not just reviving that legacy—it's modernising it for the next century.

Already, the port has catalysed 600 direct and over 5,000 indirect jobs. It is spurring investment in warehousing, bunkering, hospitality, and tourism. As it scales operations, it is poised to become a regional economic engine, powering Kerala's—and India's—ambitions.

India's boldest maritime moment

In a world shaped by how fast goods move and where they stop, Vizhinjam is more than infrastructure. It's India's boldest maritime moment in decades—a port that doesn't just greet ships, but steers strategy.

As MSC Irina sailed away, its departure wasn't just the end of a call. It was the beginning of India's deep-sea confidence.



ULCV MSC Claude Girardet at Vizhinjam on September 13, 2024.

One year of Vizhinjam

The port marked its first anniversary on July 11. Exactly one year ago, on July 11, 2024, the seaport hosted its maiden container vessel, MV San Fernando. During its first year of operations Vizhinjam port:

- Handled over 8.3 lakh TEUs
- Hosted more than 390 vessels, including 20 ULCVs
- Became the fastest-scaling port on India's southeast coast
- Trained India's first female automated crane operators from the local community

Investment: ₹10,000 crore + ($1.2 billion)
Phase 1 capacity: 1.5 million TEUs a year
Planned capacity: 4.5 million TEUs, scalable to 6.5 million TEUs a year
Berths: Initial 800 metres (to be extended by 1,200 metres)
Breakwater length: 2.96 km (deepest and among the longest in India)
Automation: Fully automated. AI-based vessel traffic management, automated cranes
Rail connectivity: 10.76 km dedicated rail corridor, of which 9 km is underground
Job creation: Over 600 direct and 5,000 indirect jobs till date
Strategic alignment: Part of PM Gati Shakti, India–Middle East–Europe Corridor (IMEC)

Source: Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways